

want to do with the rest of their lives when they're eighteen years old?

I am a “success” story, achieving FI at the age of forty-one. I developed a specialized skill set as a physical therapist. The longer I continued my practice, the less sure I became that it was what I wanted to do for the rest of my life. But I felt trapped by my success. I spent seven years and tens of thousands of dollars getting degrees that enabled this secure, well-paying job. My parents also invested heavily in my education.

Disenchantment is common for many seemingly successful professionals who seek FI as a path to freedom from high-earning jobs that don't fulfill them. Barney, author of the blog *The Escape Artist*, described this scenario: “If you're middle class, if you've been to college, in some ways the problem that you have is you have that safe option. That removes your impetus, the pressure on you to be entrepreneurial. In some ways, early career success in a relatively safe occupation can be a trap, because what's happening is you are being acclimated to a regular monthly salary, which is incredibly comforting. That leads to a bunch of behaviors around not putting that at risk.” This leads many to continue on well-paid but unfulfilling paths through life rather than pursuing the life they truly desire.